

Akshaya e-Kendras. A total of 638 e-Kendras were established across the district in the first phase of the project, which covered about a hundred Gram Panchayats and five municipalities.

In the second phase, the focus was to provide more advanced computer courses and education programmes. For the entrepreneurs who are the owners of the Akshaya e-Kendras, services such as Desktop Publishing (DTP), data entry, e-learning, computer training, and Internet telephony would be facilitated. The location of the e-Kendras was planned such that each would cover 1,000 to 3,000 households, and there would be at least one Akshaya e-Kendra available to every citizen.

The project is the first district-wide e-literacy project in India, and boasts the largest wireless networks in rural areas.

"In 2005, a programme called 'Internet for the masses' was rolled out. Earlier, a majority of the e-literacy training was imparted offline, based on CD. After the implementation of wireless networks across the districts, various online training programmes and services would be possible," says K Anvar Sadath, manager (e-governance) and head (Akshaya), Malappuram Cell.

The state tested a variety of technology options, and chose WIPLL (Wireless Internet Protocol in Local Loop). This enabled a link to each Akshaya e-Kendra with a bandwidth of 4 to 8 Mbps. The wireless connectivity in

Malappuram district was implemented by Tulip IT services, with the hardware support from US-based Airspan Networks. It was tough—the district is spread over 3,550 square kilometres, with dense vegetation and hills.

Why Malappuram?

Malappuram is the most populous district (over 36 lakh) in Kerala, with the highest population growth rate (11.4 per cent). The population density is 1,022 per square kilometre, compared to 819 in the state.

From 1.5 million people across the state, more than 3 lakh just from Malappuram district work in countries in the Gulf. But due to the lack of good educational backgrounds and exposure to IT, many of those who stay in the district have to work as labourers and in low-paying jobs. In addition, the cost of communication is very high. "The Panchayats of Malappuram district came up with a proposal to educate at least one member of each family to help them to get better jobs in Gulf countries, and also to bring down the cost of telecommunication," says Sadath.

The idea was to leverage the benefits of the available IT infrastructure through ICT. Awareness amongst the locals was created through advertisements, posters, and other methods of promotion. But word of mouth and one-to-one reference, for the most part, triggered the drive towards gaining computer literacy amongst the residents.



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Manager
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Malappuram Cell

The Akshaya e-Kendras

These are looked upon by the local people as institutions similar to schools, hospitals, or government offices. They are each equipped with five to 10 computers, a server with Internet connectivity, and printers and other peripherals. They are multi-service junctions for the residents and a source of income for the owner.

At the e-Kendras, various services are available—the e-literacy and advanced training programmes, Internet-related services, communication facilities, information about various government schemes, and e-transactions. The Akshaya centres also act as e-governance cells—they are connected with government offices via the intranet.

Online services include e-payment for electricity and telephone bills, e-Krishi for farmers for enhancing agri-based services, content development, computer-aided learning for students, e-governance, and other activities such as women's clubs for their welfare, kids' club for gaming and other entertainment activities, and so on. Students also use the Kendras for online tuitions after school hours.

Najeeb P, an entrepreneur of Akshaya Project in Moorkkanadu Panchayat, says, "I took a loan of Rs 1.5 lakh from local bank a year ago, out of which only Rs 50,000 remains to be paid. I've received good recognition amongst three wards of the Panchayat by having made 1,016 people e-literate. Even though the BSNL counter, post



Women's e-mpowerment: at the Akshaya E-Kendra in Muthiraparamba...



...everyone's invited to the e-village